

Five Elements of Shading

The components that create convincing light on form

Every lit form can be broken down into five distinct value zones. Understanding these zones — and where they appear on different shapes — gives you a systematic approach to shading any subject convincingly.

KEY CONCEPTS

1. Highlight

The lightest area, where the light source strikes the form most directly. On a shiny surface, this is a bright specular highlight. On a matte surface, it's a broader, softer light area. The highlight moves as the viewer moves.

2. Midtone / Light

The area receiving light but not the direct highlight. This is usually the largest lit area. It shows the form's local color under normal light conditions. Gradients within the midtone reveal curvature.

3. Core Shadow

The darkest part of the form shadow, just inside the terminator. This is where no direct or reflected light reaches. It should be the darkest value on the form (though not necessarily in the whole drawing).

4. Reflected Light

Light bouncing back onto the shadow side from nearby surfaces (the ground, a wall, etc.). Reflected light lightens the shadow side slightly. Common mistake: making reflected light too bright — it should remain darker than the midtone.

5. Cast Shadow

The shadow cast by the form onto surrounding surfaces. Generally darker near the form and lighter farther away. Has a defined shape that describes the form's silhouette and the direction of the light source.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Set up a sphere under a lamp. Map all 5 zones with labels before drawing.
2. Create a value scale: white → highlight → midtone → core shadow → reflected light → cast shadow.
3. Draw a portrait using only the 5-element framework. Label each zone lightly.